

1-3-1
Zone Defense

A practical coaching reference for understanding the 1-3-1.

Player roles. Ball-side pressure. Corner traps. Rotations behind the ball.

Follow each situation, then use the quick-reference pages before your next game.

Half-court coverage and three-quarter-court pressure.

1-3-1 Zone Defense

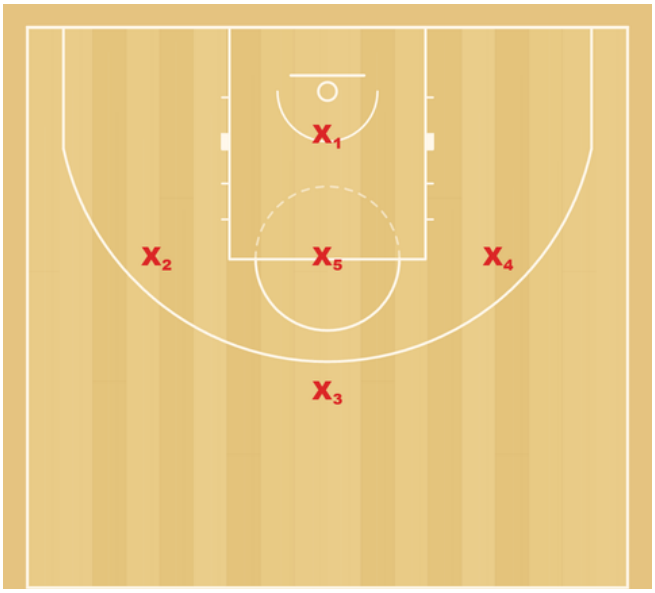
01 | Start Here

Find the Rotation You Need

A quick reference for coaches running the 1-3-1 or preparing to face it. Start with the five roles, then find the page that matches the ball position.

HOW TO USE THIS GUIDE

Setup and roles	3
Ball high or on the wing	4
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01 | Starting alignment

OUR MAIN COVERAGE

Contain the ball high. Trap the baseline corner. Protect the space behind the pressure.

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02 | Five Roles

One Up. Three Across. One Behind.

Roles describe defensive jobs, not fixed offensive positions. The alignment changes with the ball; the responsibilities stay connected.

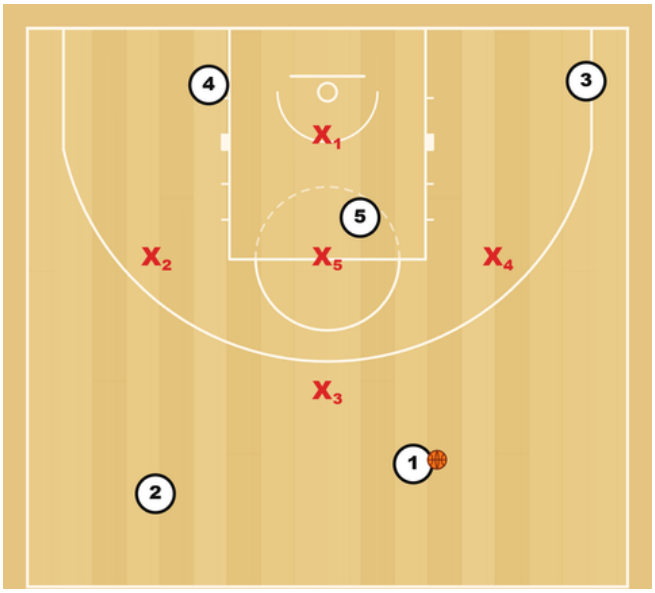
TOP (X3)
Steer the ball to a side. Deny the reversal. Drop to the high post when the ball enters the corner.

BALL-SIDE WING (X4)
Pressure the wing. Join the baseline corner trap.

MIDDLE (X5)
Deny the post entry and stop penetration. Move down to front the low post on the corner pass.

BASELINE (X1)
Cover the ball-side block and both corners. Take away the baseline drive.

WEAK-SIDE WING (X2)
Drop toward the weak-side block. Protect lobs and cuts. Close out on skip passes.



02 | The five defensive roles

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03 | Ball High

Keep the Ball on One Side

Example: the ball is high on the right. The half-court version steers it toward a sideline without sending two defenders up to trap near halfway.

TOP
Angle the dribbler toward the sideline, then make the guard-to-guard reversal difficult.

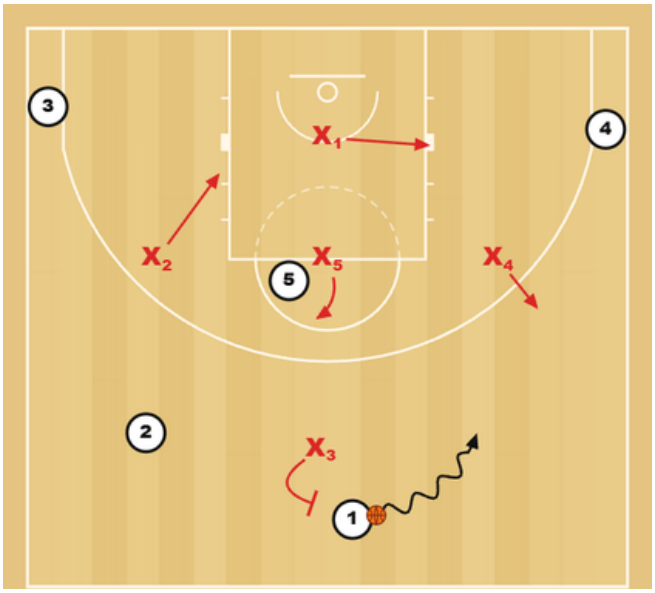
RIGHT WING
Stay lower and obstruct the direct pass toward the right corner.

MIDDLE
Deny the high-post entry and stay available against a drive.

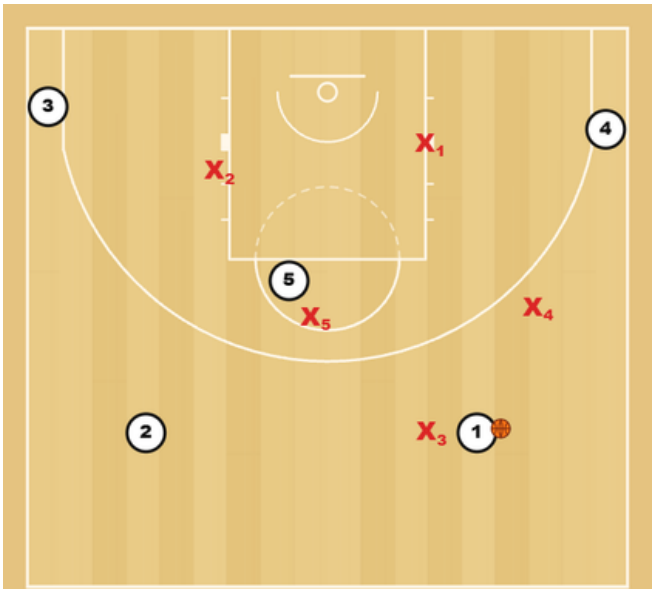
BASELINE
Shift toward the right block, ready to cover the corner.

LEFT WING
Sink toward the weak-side block and see the ball and inside threats.

KEY READ
Move while the pass travels. A late start creates the next open receiver.



03 | Ball high on the right



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04 | Ball on the Wing

Pressure Outside. Protect Behind.

Example: the ball reaches the right wing. The right wing defender pressures from the baseline hip and encourages a retreat toward half court.

<u>TOP</u>
Obstruct the return pass across the top.

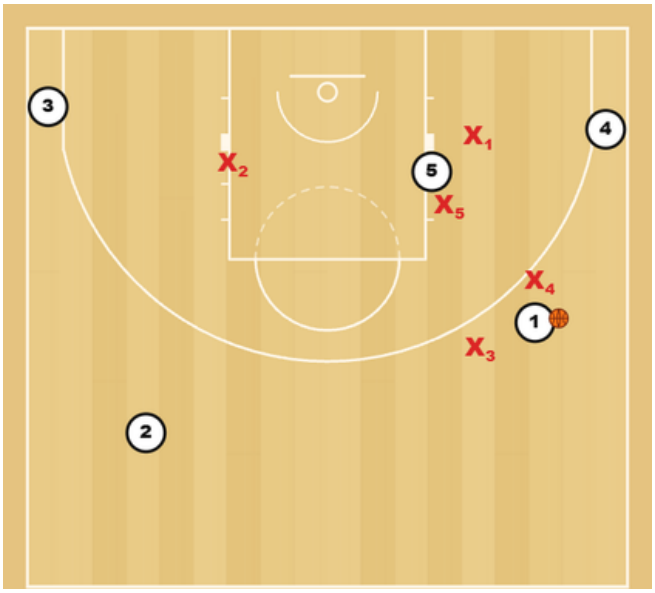
<u>RIGHT WING</u>
Pressure the ball and make the direct corner pass difficult.

<u>MIDDLE</u>
Front the post. Adjust downward if the offensive post player moves down.

<u>BASELINE</u>
Stay between the right low post and corner, ready to close out.

<u>LEFT WING</u>
Protect near the opposite block and watch the lob behind the front.

<u>KEY READ</u>
One wing is up on the ball; the other is down near the basket.



04 | Right-wing coverage

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05 | Baseline Corner

The Corner Pass Triggers the Trap

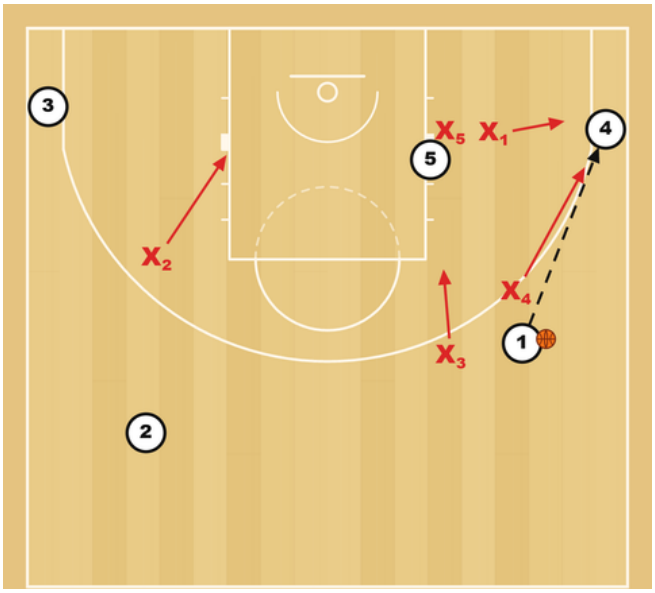
Example: the ball moves from the right wing to the right corner. Two defenders pressure the receiver while the other three cover the escape routes.

ON THE BALL
Baseline defender closes from below and denies the baseline drive.
Right wing closes from above to complete the trap.

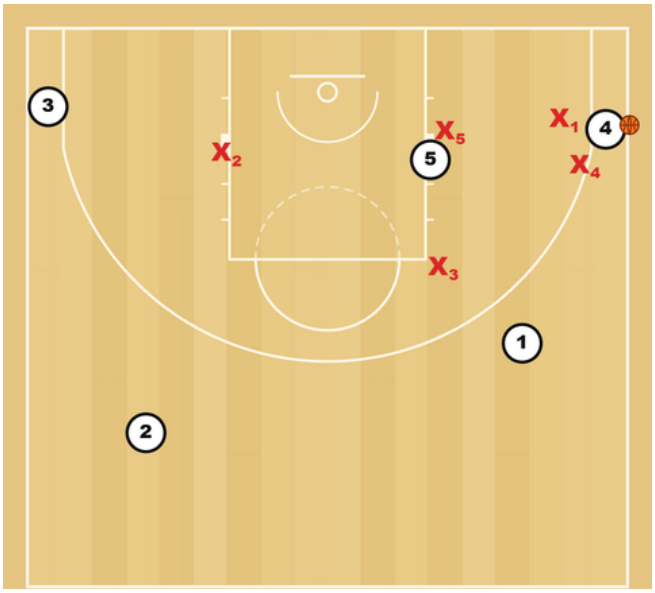
BEHIND THE TRAP
Middle fronts the right low post.
Top drops toward the right elbow to deny the high-post entry.
Left wing protects the opposite block and the space behind the front.

KEY READ
The middle moves down; the top takes over the high post.

MAIN RISK
Three defenders now cover four attackers. A clean escape pass can create an advantage.



05 | Baseline Corner



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06 | Ball Reversal

Change Sides as a Connected Unit

Example: the ball is high on the right and is passed across to the left guard. Both wings exchange jobs as the baseline defender crosses underneath.

TOP
Follow the reversal and make the return pass difficult.

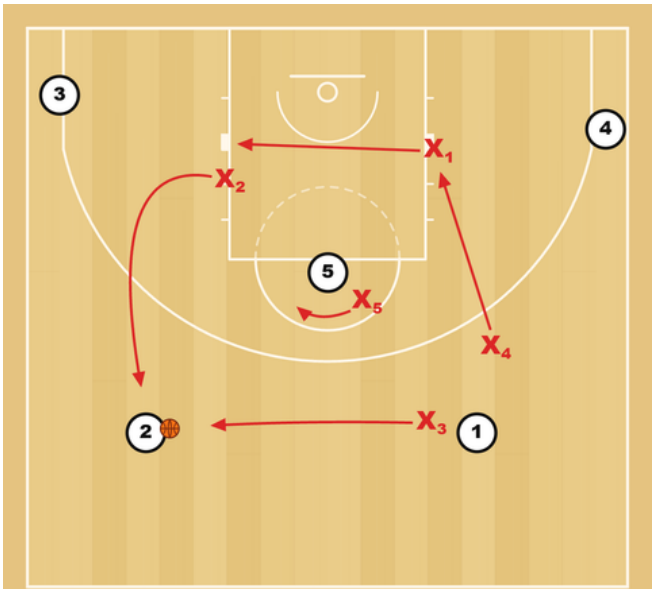
LEFT WING
Rise from the weak-side block on a curved closeout. Obstruct the immediate pass to the left corner before reaching the ball.

BASELINE
Cross to the left block and prepare for the next corner pass.

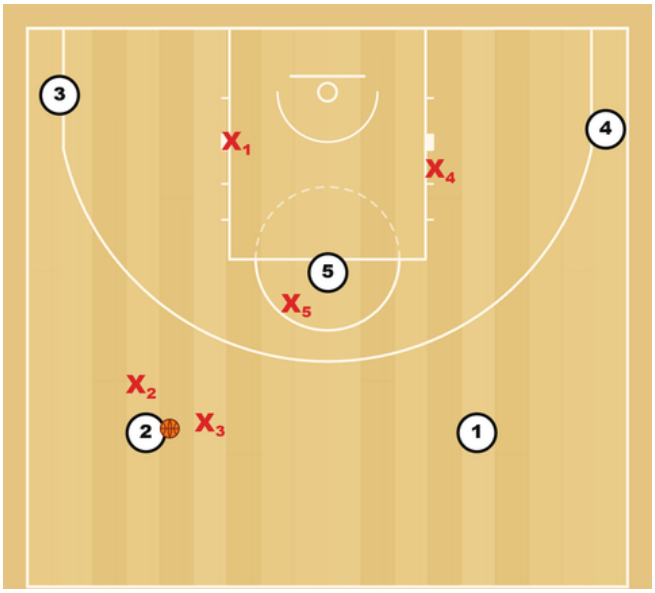
MIDDLE
Adjust to deny the post entry on the new ball side.

RIGHT WING
Drop toward the new weak-side block.

MAIN RISK
A straight sprint at the ball can leave the corner open before the baseline defender arrives.



06 | High right to left reversal



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07 | Skip to the Corner

The Weak-Side Wing Arrives First

Example: a skip pass travels from the right wing to the left corner. The weak-side wing provides the first closeout while the baseline defender crosses.

LEFT WING
Close out to the corner and take away the baseline drive.

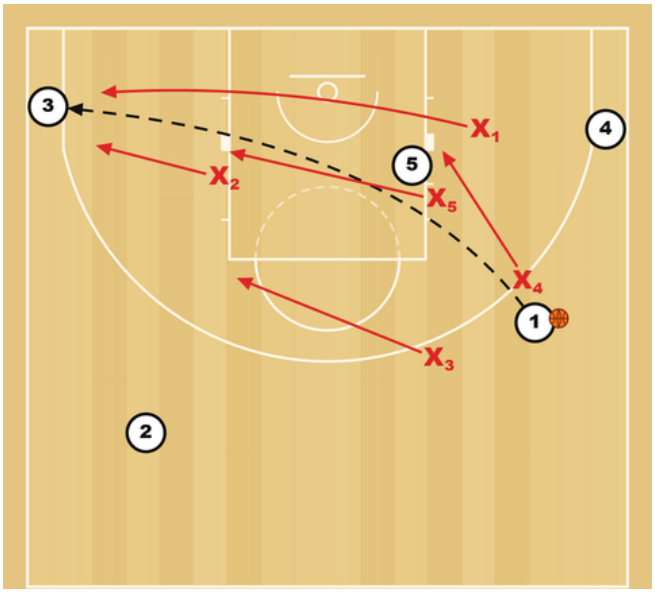
BASELINE
Sprint across to join the corner trap.

MIDDLE
Move across to front the new ball-side low post.

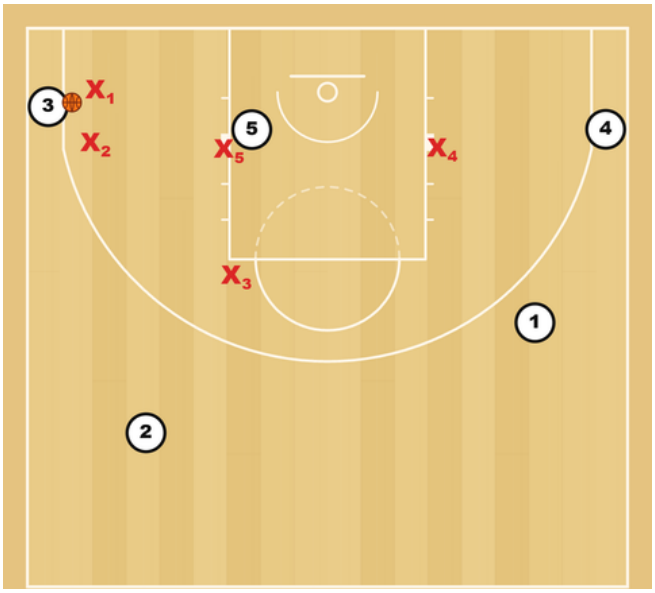
RIGHT WING
Drop toward the opposite block.

TOP
Shift across the high-post area. Be ready for the quick pass from the corner up to the wing.

COVERAGE NOTE
If the team does not trap here, the baseline defender takes over and releases the wing upward.



07 | Right wing to left corner



1-3-1 Zone Defense

08 | Skip to the Wing

The Next Corner Pass Is the Danger

Example: the ball skips from the left side to the right wing. The right wing defender closes out from the weak-side block.

RIGHT WING
Take a curved route through the passing lane to the right corner, then recover to the ball.

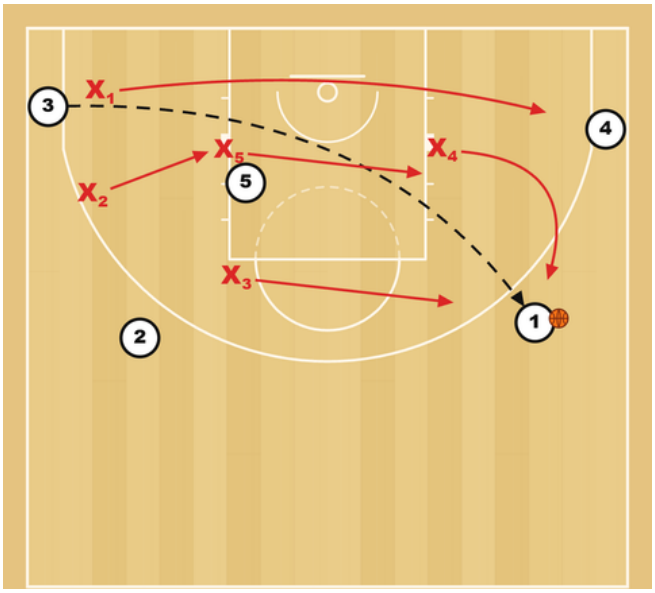
BASELINE
Cross underneath toward the new ball side.

MIDDLE
Adjust to the new ball-side post threat.

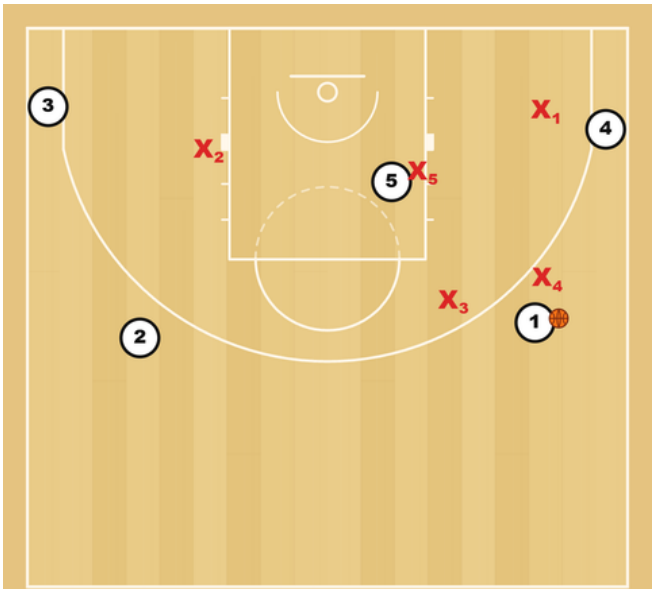
TOP
Shift across to obstruct the reversal and protect the high-post area.

LEFT WING
Drop toward the new weak-side block.

KEY READ
The first closeout must delay the second pass. Wing-to-corner can beat the baseline defender's recovery.



08 | Left side to right wing



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09 | High-Post Catch

Pressure the Catch. Protect Below.

Example: a pass from the right side reaches an attacker near the free-throw line. This catch gives the receiver access to both sides of the floor.

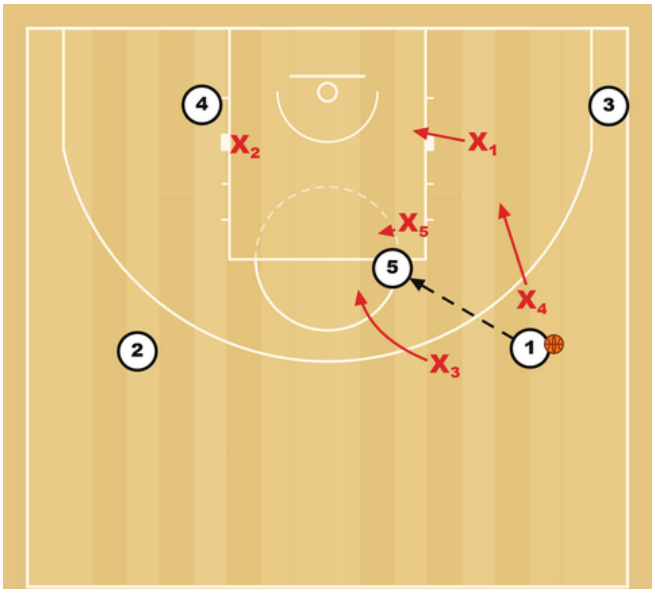
DOUBLE-TEAM
Middle contains from the basket side. Top closes down from above.

LOW COVERAGE
Baseline defender and left wing pinch in to protect the two sides of the basket.

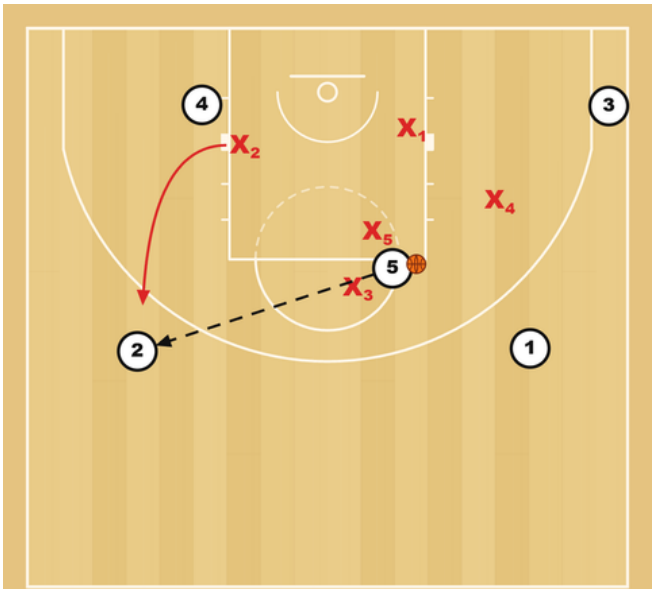
PERIMETER
Right wing stays connected to the nearby outlet.

IF THE BALL LEAVES
A pass back to the top releases the top defender upward. A skip to the left wing triggers the curved wing closeout.

MAIN RISK
A quick pass before the double arrives can find a cutter or a high-low connection.



09 | High-post catch and double



1-3-1 Zone Defense

10 | Low-Post Catch

Help Briefly. Keep the Corner Covered.

Example: the ball reaches the right block and the middle defender ends up behind the receiver. This is a recovery situation after the post denial has been beaten.

MIDDLE
Contest from the basket side.

BASELINE
Give brief help at the ball while preserving the recovery to the corner shooter.

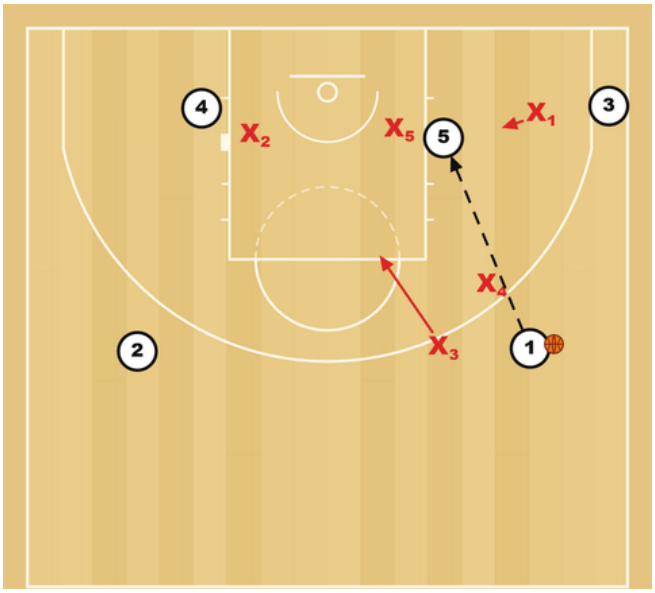
TOP
Cover the high post.

RIGHT WING
Watch the wing outlet.

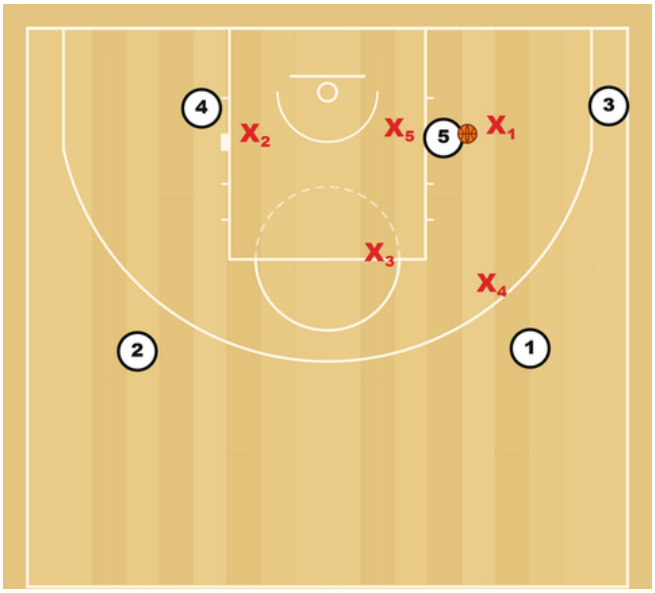
LEFT WING
Protect the weak-side block.

KEY READ
Brief help is different from staying in a full double-team.

MAIN RISK
Committing too far inside can leave an open shot on the pass back to the corner.



10 | Low-post catch



1-3-1 Zone Defense

11 | Dribble Penetration

Stop the Drive. Fill the Space Behind.

Example: the ball handler drives between the top defender and the right wing. The middle defender becomes the first inside helper.

MIDDLE
Step up to stop the drive.

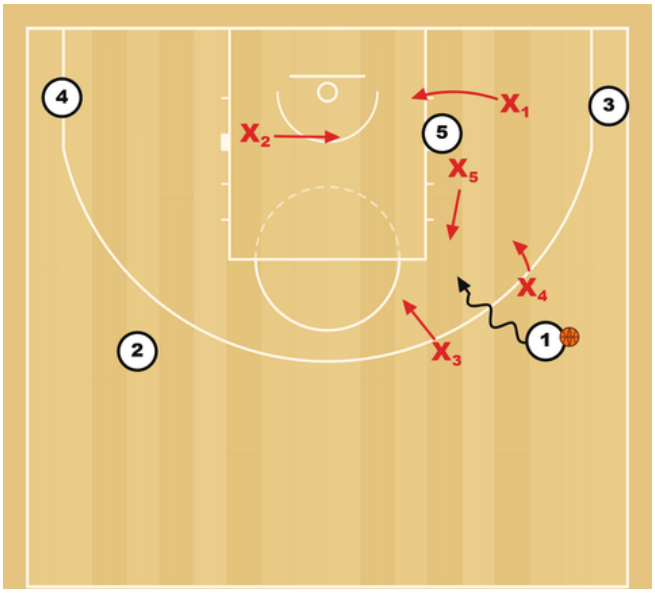
BASELINE + LEFT WING
Tighten toward the basket and protect the space behind that help.

TOP + RIGHT WING
Recover and make the next pass difficult.

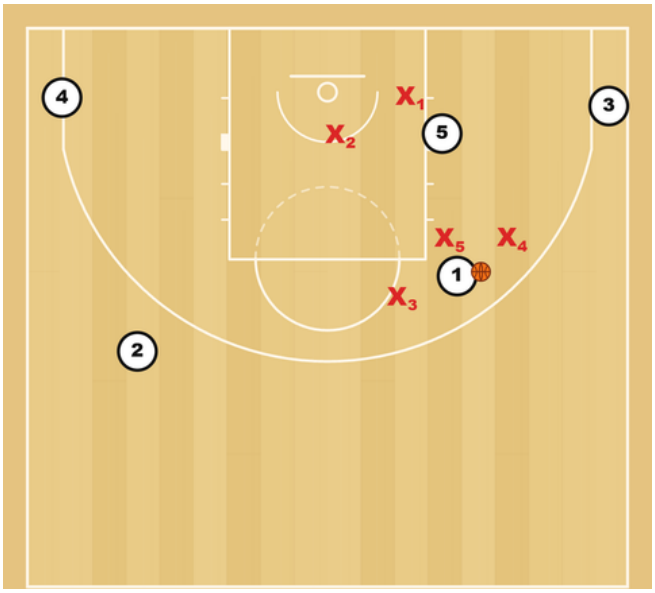
ON THE PASS OUT
Spread back into the defensive responsibilities on the new ball side.

KEY READ
The helper's movement changes everyone else's job.

MAIN RISK
Holding the original alignment leaves the middle defender isolated and exposes the basket behind the play.



11 | Drive through the upper gap



1-3-1 Zone Defense

12 | Extended Pressure

Pick Up Earlier in Three-Quarter Court

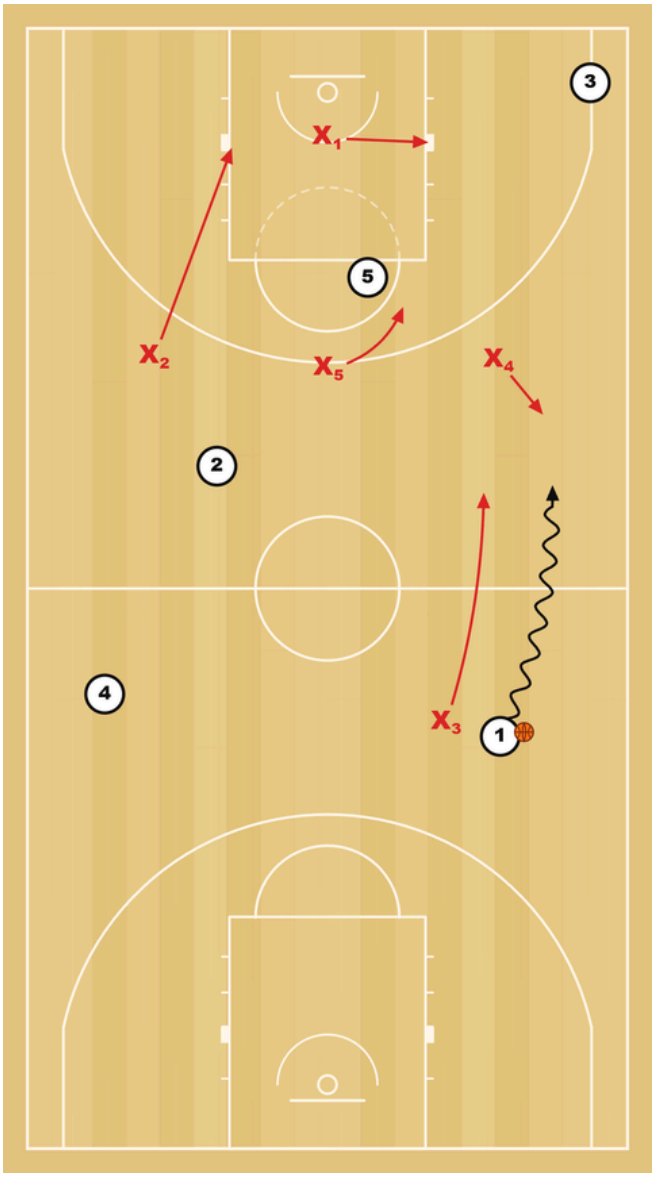
The extended version applies pressure before the offense settles into the half court. The top defender starts higher and guides the ball toward a sideline.

AS THE BALL CROSSES HALFWAY
The ball-side wing steps up to help the top defender.

SOFT TRAP
Leave some space around the dribbler. The wing blocks the route down the sideline; the top discourages the reversal.

BEHIND THE PRESSURE
Middle protects the high-post area. Baseline covers the ball-side block. Opposite wing protects near the weak-side block.

KEY READ
Earlier pressure leaves more court behind the first two defenders. The back three must move with the ball.



12 | Three-quarter-court pressure

Soft or Hard? Know the Difference.

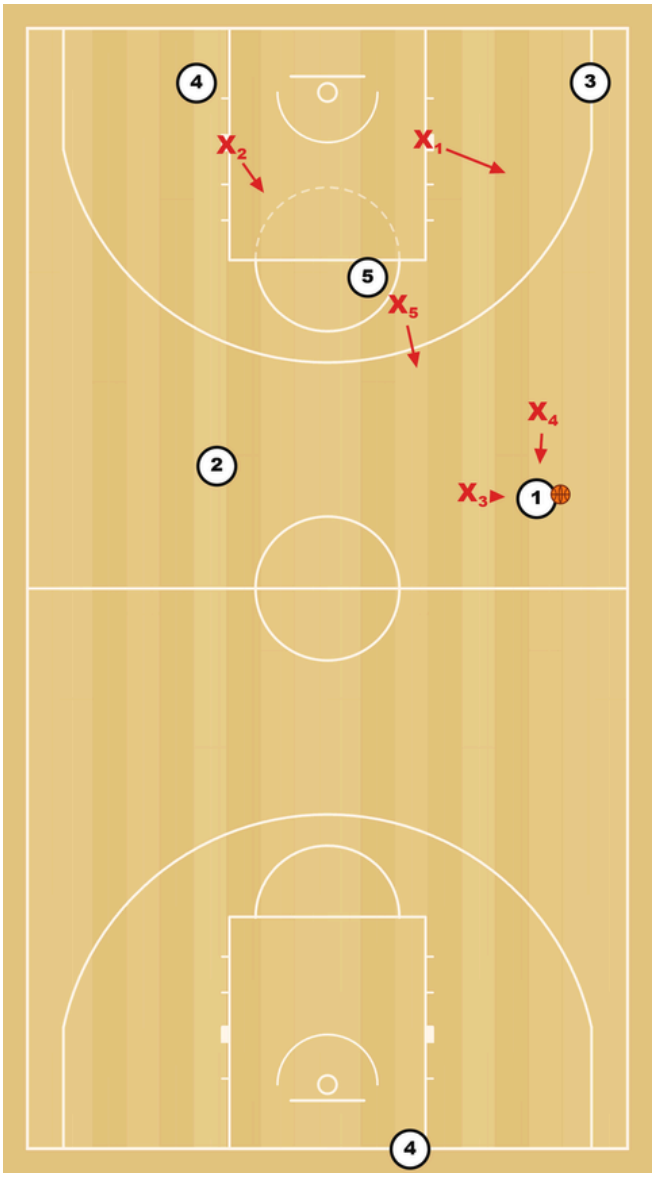
These are pressure choices within the system. A team's actual trapping rules tell you more than the 1-3-1 starting shape alone.

SOFT TRAP NEAR HALFWAY
Top and wing leave room around the dribbler while obstructing the sideline route and reversal.

HARD TRAP NEAR HALFWAY
Both defenders close the space around the ball. The other three step into likely escape lanes and anticipate the pass.

BASELINE CORNER
Our main half-court example uses a hard trap from the wing and baseline defender.

THE TRADE-OFF
Harder pressure can disrupt tempo and create possessions. A clean escape pass leaves fewer defenders covering more space.



13 | Soft versus hard pressure

Finish the Possession with All Five

Example: a shot goes up from the right corner. The defensive alignment must become rebounding coverage before anyone thinks about transition offense.

MIDDLE
Establish position on the ball side.

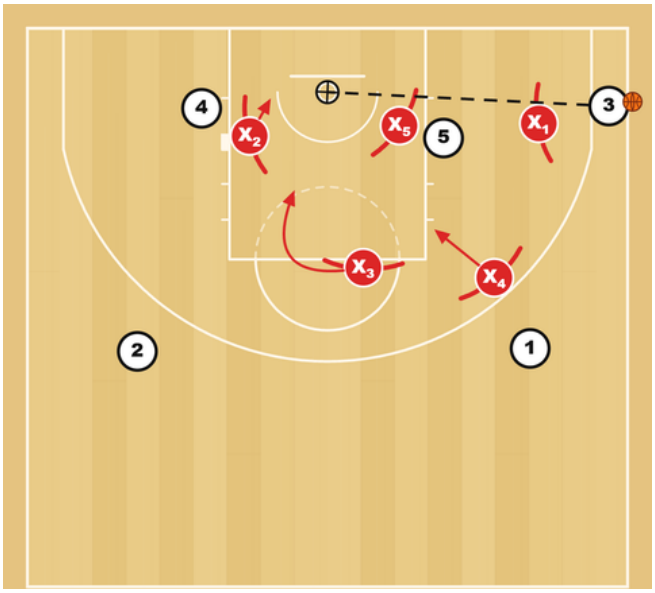
LEFT WING
Find a threat on the weak side.

TOP
Come down to help rebound on that same weak side.

RIGHT WING + BASELINE
One contests the shot; the other closes in to help rebound. The contesting defender also accounts for the shooter.

KEY READ
Find opponents as well as positions.

MAIN RISK
If all five simply turn toward the ball, attackers can run through the gaps for a second shot.



14 | Rebound after a corner shot

1-3-1 Zone Defense

15 | Strengths and Costs

Pressure Works Only with Coverage

The 1-3-1 can change the rhythm of a game. Its benefits and weaknesses come from the same choice: putting pressure on the ball and the passing lanes.

WHAT IT CAN CREATE
Disrupted passing patterns.
Deflections and turnovers.
A different tempo for the offense.

WHAT IT DEMANDS
Anticipation and connected rotations.
Long recoveries to the corners.
Reliable help behind post fronts.
All five involved in rebounding.

WHERE IT CAN BREAK
The middle, the opposite side and the space behind the zone.

KEY READ
Length helps. Understanding who covers the next space is what connects the defense.

Find Drills. Draw Plays. Build Practices.

Use the Basketball Orbit Practice Planner to discover game-like drills, create your own diagrams, and turn everything into organized practice plans.

Start Planning Your Next Practice
👉 https://app.bballorbit.com



1-3-1 Zone Defense

16 | Spot the Breakdown

Check the Rotation Behind the Ball

Use these checks when a possession breaks down. Follow the responsibility that changed as the ball moved, rather than judging only the defender nearest the shot.

✅ OPEN HIGH POST FROM THE CORNER?
Check whether the top defender dropped to the ball-side elbow.

✅ LOB OVER THE POST FRONT?
Check the weak-side wing's help position.

✅ OPEN CORNER AFTER A SKIP?
Check the wing's closeout route and the baseline defender's recovery.

✅ LAYUP BEHIND A DRIVE?
Check whether the baseline defender and weak-side wing pinched in.

✅ SECOND-CHANCE SHOT?
Check who found the rebounders, not just who watched the ball.

1-3-1 Zone Defense

17 | Rotation Lookup

What Changes When the Ball Moves?

Use this page as a fast reminder of the main exchanges. Read the trigger first, then follow the defenders whose responsibilities change.

WING TO CORNER
Baseline + ball-side wing trap.
Middle moves to the low post.
Top takes over the high post.

REVERSAL
New ball-side wing comes up.
Previous ball-side wing drops.
Baseline crosses underneath.

SKIP TO CORNER
Weak-side wing closes first.
Baseline crosses to join or take over.

HIGH-POST CATCH
Top + middle double.
Baseline + weak-side wing protect below.

DRIVE INSIDE
Middle stops the ball.
Baseline + weak-side wing fill behind.

1-3-1 Zone Defense

18 | Game-Day Reference

Five Questions Before the Next Possession

For your own defense or an opponent's 1-3-1, identify the actual coverage first. The same formation can produce different pressure and recovery choices.

1. WHERE DOES PRESSURE START?
Half court, or farther up the floor?

2. WHERE ARE THE TRAPS?
Baseline corners only, or also near halfway?

3. WHO TAKES THE CORNER?
On a normal pass: the baseline defender.
On a skip: the weak-side wing arrives first.

4. WHO COVERS BEHIND THE BALL?
Track the high-post exchange and the weak-side help.

5. WHO FINISHES THE POSSESSION?
All five find rebounding responsibilities.

REMEMBER
When one defender moves toward the ball, someone else must cover the space that opens.

For more details and teaching points, check out my video on YouTube:

1-3-1 Zone Defense Explained: Rotations, Traps & Weaknesses

Basketball Orbit

Where strategy meets passion —this is Basketball Orbit



Hi, I'm Chris – Welcome to Basketball Orbit!

Basketball has been a huge part of my life. Growing up in Germany, I fell in love with the game and have been lucky to play it for most of my life. Over the years, my passion evolved into coaching, where I've worked with players and teams of all levels — from beginners to experienced athletes.

Coaching can be challenging — planning practices, teaching plays, and motivating players isn't always easy. That's why I started Basketball Orbit: to share the strategies and tools I've learned to help coaches like you create confident, successful teams.

On my YouTube channel, I focus on practical drills, plays, and strategies for youth and senior teams alike. My goal is simple: to help you grow as a coach and take your team to the next level.

Basketball is about more than just winning — it's about teamwork, resilience, and having fun. Join me on this journey, and let's build stronger teams together.

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